



When outcomes and outputs (deliverables) are shown separately in a report, can the alignment between them be established?

One would think that one key use of an initiative's reporting documentation (for instance a government agency's) would be to enable a reader to quickly check that outputs (deliverables) are aligned to outcomes - essential for ensuring an effective initiative. Indeed, reports about initiatives often do provide lists of outcomes and outputs - but usually as separate lists. If the lists are separate it is hard to work out if there is, in fact, alignment. To easily determine alignment between outputs and outcomes, both need to be presented within the same integrated representation, whether it be a: text-based list; table; database; or, strategy/outcomes diagram. Such a representation needs to include all outcomes and outputs, plus the relationship between them. However, if these outcomes and outputs are presented in separate sections of a report, it's often not possible to work out whether there's alignment between them.

Usually, outcomes (sometimes broken up into several levels of outcomes) are listed in a text, table or visual format. However, it's usually thought inappropriate to include details of outputs and their measures in such outcomes lists - because it's thought that outputs and measures belong in the 'outputs' section of the report. Outputs are also usually set out separately. Good accounting practice is for outputs lists - often called 'statements of service performance' or 'deliverables lists' - to not include outcomes that are not directly controllable by an agency or initiative. These outputs lists are typically used for accountability, contracting or delegation and in government are usually audited to ensure the agency or initiative delivers on them. Accounting practice requires excluding not-necessarily controllable (non-attributable) from outputs lists because of the difficulty of definitely establishing that the initiative caused them. Consequently, neither the 'outcomes' nor the 'outputs' list includes the other and the relationship between them is usually hard to identify just by looking at the separate lists. In contrast, an integrated outcomes/outputs representation such as a DoView strategy/outcomes diagram, with outputs mapped onto outcomes, allows the reader to check alignment of outputs with priority outcome. To deal with the accountability question, direct accountabilities (outputs/deliverables) can be marked up within such representations (see Developing or Reviewing an Outputs/Deliverables List Tool (D8)).

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